



Ayurvedic market doctor. Practitioners prescribe herbal remedies on the basis of their attributes – “warm” and “cool” are but two of them. The Ayurvedic practitioner’s aim is to balance the patient’s doshas, the principles that regulate sickness and health.

(*kapha*) and decrease air (*vata*); bitter, pungent, and astringent remedies increase air and decrease water; and sour, salty, and pungent herbs increase fire (*pitta*).

Preparations & Treatments

In addition to plant extracts, Ayurvedic medicines include honey and dairy produce, and sometimes minute doses of minerals such as salt are added. Remedies take the form of pills, powders, balms, and infusions, and most contain several different ingredients, all carefully balanced to individual needs. Treatment might include washes and enemas or the application of poultices as well as massage with warm herbal oil, burning incense, the use of precious stones and metals, and ritual purification for imbalanced mind and emotions. The chanting of mantras (incantations based on sacred texts), breathing, and meditation exercises may be advised, due to the power of sound and the effect of vibration and meditation on the body, mind, and spirit.

Herbal Medicine in India Today

In the 19th century, the British dismissed Ayurveda as mere superstition, and in 1833 they closed all Ayurvedic schools and banned the practice. Great centers of Indian learning thus fell apart, and Ayurvedic knowledge retreated into villages and temples. At the turn of the century, however, some Indian physicians and enlightened Englishmen began to reevaluate Ayurveda, and by the time of India’s independence in 1947 it had regained its reputation as a valid medical system. Today, Ayurveda flourishes side by side with Unani Tibb and Western conventional medicine and is actively encouraged by the Indian government as an inexpensive alternative to Western drugs. In recent years, Ayurveda has attracted increasing attention from medical scientists in the West and in Japan, and the World Health Organization has resolved to promote its practice in developing countries.

Ayurveda’s value lies in the fact that it is not a medical science dealing solely with treatment of disease. Instead, it offers practical guidelines that apply to every facet of daily existence. It also seeks to reconcile health and lifestyle with universal aspects of existence, and to enhance well-being and promote longevity.

Sweet flag (*Acorus calamus*, p. 57). The rhizome is taken as a tonic and as an aphrodisiac.

Fresh sweet flag

Dried sweet flag

Chiretta (*Swertia chirata*, p. 273) is a strongly bitter herb used to treat excess *pitta* (fire), marked by fever and liver problems.

Pomegranate (*Punica granatum*, p. 259) is used to make a traditional Ayurvedic remedy for dysentery.

Pomegranate flower

Pomegranate fruit

Tea (*Camellia sinensis*, p. 181) is astringent and tonic.

Ginger (*Zingiber officinale*, p. 155) is known as the “universal medicine” in Ayurveda. It is particularly helpful for relieving nausea and indigestion.

Ginger root

Ginger powder